His image suffered from a trust deficit *vis-à-vis* those addressed: this is evident. Presumably, these borderers would have been privy to the ruthless way in which Ashoka had run over Kalinga and may have feared they were next in line. Ashoka is at pains to persuade them otherwise.

As for Ashoka's subjects in Kalinga, his main concern in Separate Rock Edict 1, what exactly was he asking his administration to do even as he addressed all and sundry as his progeny? If one pays heed to a strong hint in the edict, he was looking at ways of changing and improving an insensitive Mauryan administration in Kalinga. He alludes to this when he exhorts officials to pay attention to being even-handed in the administration of justice ('niti'), and to cultivate the right qualities necessary to the discharge of their duties:

> It happens in the administration (of justice) that a single person suffers either imprisonment or harsh treatment.
>
> In this case (an order) cancelling the imprisonment is obtained by him accidentally, while (many) other people continue to suffer.
>
> In this case you must strive to deal (with all of them) impartially.
>
> But if one fails to act (thus) on account of the following dispositions: envy, anger, cruelty, hurry, want of practice, laziness, (and) fatigue.
>
> (You) must strive for this, that these dispositions may not arise to you.
>
> And the root of all this is the absence of anger and the avoidance of hurry.
>
> He who is fatigued in the administration (of justice), will not rise; but one ought to move, to walk, and to advance.[47]

Ashoka seems very aware that all was not quiet on the eastern front. Looking for words to motivate his administration there, he was unequivocal about the dire consequences of failure: 'there will be neither attainment of heaven nor satisfaction of the king'. They would attain heaven and pay the king's debt by listening carefully.[48]

The idea of paying a debt had figured in the Sixth Edict, where Ashoka spoke of discharging the debt he owed to living beings.[49] Now, in this new